

53.3 Summary: Pronoun Agreement (สรุป ความสอดคล้องของสรรพนาม + 50 Exercises)

ยินดีต้อนรับสืบทสรวบยอดของ Pronoun-Antecedent Agreement ครบ ในระดับ C1-C2 นี้ เราจะก้าวข้ามกฎพื้นฐานและเจาะลึกไปยังความซับซ้อนที่มักสร้างความสับสนแม้แต่กับผู้เรียนระดับสูง หัวใจสำคัญยังคงเดิม: 'สรรพนาม (Pronoun) ต้องสอดคล้องกับคำนามที่มันอ้างถึง (Antecedent) ทั้งในเรื่องพจน์ (Number) และเพศ (Gender)' แต่ความท้าทายอยู่ที่การระบุ Antecedent ที่แท้จริงในประโยคที่ซับซ้อน

****ประเด็นสำคัญที่ต้องทบทวนในระดับสูง:****

1. ****Indefinite Pronouns (สรรพนามไม่ชี้เฉพาะ):****

****Singular เสมอ:**** `each`, `every`, `either`, `neither`, `one`, `anyone`, `anybody`, `anything`, `someone`, `somebody`, `something`, `everyone`, `everybody`, `everything`, `no one`, `nobody`, `nothing`. แม้ความหมายจะดูเหมือนหลายคน แต่ในทางไวยากรณ์ถือเป็นเอกพจน์ -> `Each of the scientists presented *his or her* findings.`

****Plural เสมอ:**** `both`, `few`, `many`, `several` -> `Several of the candidates have submitted *their* portfolios.`

****เป็นได้ทั้ง Singular และ Plural (SAMAN Rule):**** `Some`, `Any`, `Most`, `All`, `None`. พจน์ของสรรพนามเหล่านี้ขึ้นอยู่กับคำนามที่ตามหลังในวลีบุพบท (prepositional phrase) -> `Some of the *information* was outdated, so *it* was disregarded.` (information เป็นนามนับไม่ได้ -> singular) vs. `Some of the *delegates* left early; *they* had other commitments.` (delegates เป็นนามพหูพจน์ -> plural).

2. ****Collective Nouns (สมุหนาม):****

คำนาม เช่น `team`, `committee`, `jury`, `audience`, `family`, `corporation` สามารถเป็นได้ทั้งเอกพจน์และพหูพจน์ ขึ้นอยู่กับบริบท

****Singular:**** เมื่อมองเป็นหน่วยเดียวกัน ทำสิ่งเดียวกัน -> `The committee submits *its* final report tomorrow.` (คณะกรรมการทั้งชุดส่งรายงาน 1 ฉบับ)

****Plural:**** เมื่อสมาชิกในกลุ่มทำกิจกรรมต่างกัน หรือเน้นความเป็นปัจเจกบุคคล -> `The committee are debating among *themselves* about the final wording.` (สมาชิกแต่ละคนกำลังถกเถียงกัน)

3. ****Compound Antecedents (คำนามเชื่อมกัน):****

****เชื่อมด้วย 'and':**** โดยทั่วไปเป็นพหูพจน์ -> `The CEO and the CFO value *their*

privacy.`

* **เชื่อมด้วย 'or', 'nor', 'either...or', 'neither...nor':** สรรพนามจะสอดคล้องกับ Antecedent ที่อยู่ 'ใกล้ที่สุด' (Proximity Rule) -> `Neither the project managers nor the chief engineer could find \*his\* misplaced blueprints.` (สรรพนาม `his` สอดคล้องกับ `chief engineer` ซึ่งเป็นเอกพจน์และอยู่ใกล้กว่า)

4. **The 'One of those who...' Trap (กับดักโครงสร้าง 'หนึ่งใน...ผู้ซึ่ง'):**

นี่คือจุดที่ผิดบ่อยที่สุดในระดับสูง! ในโครงสร้าง 'one of the [plural noun] that/who...' Antecedent ของ `who/that` คือคำนามพหูพจน์ที่อยู่ข้างหน้า ไม่ใช่ `one` ดังนั้นกริยาและสรรพนามที่ตามมาต้องเป็นพหูพจน์ -> `Dr. Evans is one of those researchers who consistently challenge \*their\* own assumptions.` (Antecedent ของ `who` คือ `researchers` (พหูพจน์) ไม่ใช่ `one` ดังนั้นจึงใช้ `their`)

5. **Gender-Neutral Language (ภาษาที่ไม่ระบุเพศ):**

ในงานเขียนเชิงวิชาการหรือทางการ เมื่อ Antecedent เป็นเอกพจน์ที่ไม่ระบุเพศ (เช่น `a student`, `an applicant`), มี 3 ทางเลือก:

* `he or she` / `his or her` (เป็นทางการที่สุด): `Each applicant must submit \*his or her\* resume.`

* ทำให้ Antecedent เป็นพหูพจน์: `All applicants must submit \*their\* resumes.`

* ใช้ 'Singular They' (ยอมรับมากขึ้นเรื่อยๆ): `Each applicant must submit \*their\* resume.`
การใช้ Singular 'they' เป็นที่ยอมรับในสถานการณ์ส่วนใหญ่แล้ว แต่ควรตรวจสอบตามข้อกำหนดของสถาบันหรือองค์กรนั้นๆ

การเข้าใจกฎเกณฑ์ที่ซับซ้อนเหล่านี้จะยกระดับการเขียนและการใช้ภาษาอังกฤษของคุณให้แม่นยำและเป็นธรรมชาติเหมือนเจ้าของภาษาอย่างแท้จริงครับ

Examples (ตัวอย่างการใช้งาน)

GB The faculty, profoundly divided on the new curriculum, have voiced their disparate opinions in the latest departmental memo, indicating that a consensus is far from being reached.

TH คณะคณาจารย์ ซึ่งมีความคิดเห็นแตกแยกอย่างลึกซึ้งเกี่ยวกับหลักสูตรใหม่ ได้แสดงความคิดเห็นที่แตกต่างกันของพวกเขาในบันทึกของภาควิชาฉบับล่าสุด ซึ่งบ่งชี้ว่ายังอีกไกลกว่าจะหาข้อสรุปร่วมกันได้ **คำอธิบาย:** ในที่นี้ 'faculty' (คณะคณาจารย์) ซึ่งเป็น Collective Noun ถูกใช้ในความหมายพหูพจน์ เพราะประโยคเน้นความแตกแยกและความคิดเห็นที่ 'แตกต่างกัน' (disparate opinions) ของสมาชิกแต่ละคน จึงใช้สรรพนาม 'their' เพื่อสะท้อนความเป็นปัจเจกบุคคล

GB Neither the maverick CEO nor the board of directors, despite their protracted negotiations, could align their visions for the company's future.

TH ทั้ง CEO ผู้มีความคิดอิสระและคณะกรรมการบริษัท แม้จะมีการเจรจาที่ยืดเยื้อ ก็ไม่สามารถปรับวิสัยทัศน์ของพวกเขาสำหรับอนาคตของบริษัทให้ตรงกันได้ **คำอธิบาย:** นี่คือตัวอย่างกฎ Proximity Rule ของ 'neither...nor'. Antecedent ที่อยู่ใกล้สรรพนามที่สุดคือ 'the board of directors' ซึ่งเป็นคำนามพหูพจน์ (เมื่อพิจารณาในฐานะกลุ่มบุคคล) ดังนั้นสรรพนามที่ถูกต้องคือ 'their'

GB This corporation is one of those behemoths that prioritize shareholder profits above all else, often at the expense of their employees' well-being.

TH บริษัทนี้เป็นหนึ่งในบรรดาบริษัทยักษ์ใหญ่ที่ให้ความสำคัญกับผลกำไรของผู้ถือหุ้นเหนือสิ่งอื่นใด ซึ่งมักจะต้องแลกมาด้วยสวัสดิภาพของพนักงานของพวกเขา **คำอธิบาย:** ตัวอย่างคลาสสิกของ 'one of those who/that...' trap. Antecedent ของ 'that' คือ 'behemoths' (บริษัทยักษ์ใหญ่) ซึ่งเป็นพหูพจน์ ไม่ใช่ 'one' ดังนั้น สรรพนามที่อ้างถึงบริษัทยักษ์ใหญ่เหล่านั้นในส่วนท้ายของประโยค จึงต้องเป็นพหูพจน์ คือ 'their'

GB None of the classified intelligence, meticulously gathered over decades, had its veracity questioned until the recent security breach.

TH ไม่มีข้อมูลข่าวกรองลับใดๆ ที่ถูกรวบรวมอย่างพิถีพิถันมานานหลายทศวรรษ เคยถูกตั้งคำถามถึงความถูกต้องของมัน จนกระทั่งเกิดเหตุการณ์การละเมิดความปลอดภัยเมื่อไม่นานมานี้ **คำอธิบาย:** 'None' เป็นสรรพนามที่พจน์ขึ้นอยู่กับการตามมา ในที่นี้ 'intelligence' เป็นนามนับไม่ได้ (uncountable noun) จึงถือเป็นเอกพจน์ ดังนั้นสรรพนามที่ใช้อ้างถึงจึงต้องเป็นเอกพจน์ 'its'

⚠ Common Mistakes (จุดที่มักทำผิดพลาด)

****1. The 'One of those who...' Trap:**** ผิดพลาดบ่อยที่สุดในระดับสูง คือการใช้สรรพนามเอกพจน์ตามโครงสร้างนี้ เพราะถูกดึงความสนใจไปที่คำว่า 'one' ลืมไปว่า Antecedent ที่แท้จริงของ relative pronoun คือคำนามพหูพจน์ที่อยู่ติดกัน

ผิด. `She is one of the managers who always puts *her* team first.`

ถูก. `She is one of the managers who always put *their* teams first.` (who ในที่นี้หมายถึง the managers)

****2. Misinterpreting Collective Nouns:**** ใช้สรรพนามเอกพจน์กับ Collective Noun เสมอโดยไม่พิจารณาบริบทว่ากลุ่มนั้นกำลังทำสิ่งเดียวกันเป็นหนึ่งเดียว (singular) หรือสมาชิกแต่ละคนกำลังทำสิ่งต่างๆ แยกกัน (plural)

ผิด (ถ้าเน้นความขัดแย้ง): `The jury argued for hours before reaching *its* verdict.`

ถูก (เมื่อเน้นการกระทำของแต่ละคน): `The jury argued for hours before reaching \*their\* verdict.` (ถ้าจะให้เคลียร์กว่านี้ อาจจะพูดว่า The jury members argued...)

****3. Proximity Rule with 'Or/Nor':**** สับสนกับกฎ 'คำนามที่อยู่ใกล้ที่สุด' โดยเฉพาะในประโยคยาวๆ ที่มีวลีแทรก ทำให้ระบุ Antecedent ที่ใกล้ที่สุดผิดพลาด และเลือกใช้สรรพนามตามคำนามตัวแรกแทน

ผิด: `Neither the interns nor the senior analyst submitted \*their\* reports on time.` (ถ้า analyst มีคนเดียว)

ถูก: `Neither the interns nor the senior analyst submitted \*his\* (or \*her\*) report on time.`

****4. Indefinite Pronouns + Prepositional Phrases:**** สับสนกับกลุ่ม SAMAN (`Some, Any, Most, All, None`) โดยมักจะเผลอใช้สรรพนามพหูพจน์ตามหลัง `None of the...` แม้ว่าคำนามที่ตามมาจะเป็นเอกพจน์หรือนับไม่ได้ก็ตาม

ผิด: `None of the equipment has had \*their\* maintenance checks.`

ถูก: `None of the equipment has had \*its\* maintenance checks.` (equipment เป็นนามนับไม่ได้)



Practice Exercises (50 Questions)

1. The board of directors, after a contentious six-hour meeting, finally reached a consensus on _____ new strategic direction.

- A. their
- B. its
- C. it's
- D. theirs

2. Each of the researchers, despite facing innumerable setbacks, was resolute in _____ pursuit of a breakthrough.

- A. their
- B. his or her
- C. its
- D. theirs

3. Dr. Alistair is one of those formidable academics who never shy away from challenging _____ own established theories.

- A. his
- B. their
- C. his or her
- D. ones

4. Neither the sprawling metropolis nor the quaint surrounding villages could retain _____ historical character in the face of rapid modernization.

- A. its
- B. their
- C. their own
- D. its own

5. A number of esoteric documents, long thought to be lost, have had _____ authenticity verified by a team of leading historians.

- A. its
- B. it's
- C. they're
- D. their

6. The jury delivered _____ verdict unanimously, finding the defendant not guilty on all counts.

- A. their
- B. its
- C. his or her
- D. theirs

7. Everybody who has ever grappled with existential philosophy must, at some point, confront _____ own mortality.

- A. their
- B. his
- C. his or her
- D. ones

8. The phenomenon of quantum entanglement, as well as its perplexing implications, has _____ roots in the early 20th century.

- A. its
- B. their
- C. it's
- D. his

9. Some of the antiquated software is so unreliable that _____ continued use poses a significant security risk.

- A. its
- B. their
- C. it
- D. they

10. It is not the politicians but the electorate that must ultimately bear the responsibility for _____ choices.

- A. its
- B. his or her
- C. their
- D. your

11. Neither of the proposed solutions seems to offer _____ proponents a clear path to success.

- A. its
- B. their
- C. it's
- D. theirs

12. The alumni of the university, who now hold influential positions globally, often credit _____ alma mater for their success.

- A. its
- B. his or her
- C. their
- D. their's

13. Every cog and wheel in the intricate mechanism has _____ own specific function.

- A. its
- B. their
- C. his or her
- D. our

14. All of the information disseminated by the agency had _____ sources carefully redacted.

- A. their
- B. its
- C. it's
- D. they're

15. The committee members are currently embroiled in a debate among _____ about the allocation of funds.

- A. itself
- B. himself
- C. themselves
- D. theirselves

16. He is the only one of the programmers who understands how to debug the legacy system on _____ own.

- A. his
- B. their
- C. its
- D. ones

17. Mathematics, along with theoretical physics, has _____ own set of immutable laws.

- A. their
- B. it's
- C. its
- D. theirs

18. Many a political pundit has had to retract _____ predictions after an unexpected election result.

- A. their
- B. his or her
- C. ones
- D. its

19. Either the regional managers or the vice president will have to present _____ revised proposal at the summit.

- A. their
- B. his
- C. her
- D. his or her

20. The United States, despite its diverse population, holds _____ elections every four years.

- A. their
- B. it's
- C. its
- D. our

21. The flock of migratory birds makes _____ arduous journey south every autumn.

- A. its
- B. their
- C. it's
- D. theirs

22. None of the delegates were willing to compromise on _____ core principles.

- A. his or her
- B. its
- C. they're
- D. their

23. The plethora of data available has overwhelmed the analysts, making _____ task of finding a clear trend nearly impossible.

- A. their
- B. its
- C. his or her
- D. the

24. A person who is perpetually indecisive often finds _____ caught between equally unappealing options.

- A. themselves
- B. himself
- C. himself or herself
- D. itself

25. It was the CEO, not her subordinates, who had to stake _____ entire reputation on the risky venture.

- A. their
- B. her
- C. his
- D. its

26. The company's new AI, an amalgam of various complex algorithms, constantly updates _____ own programming.

- A. their
- B. its
- C. it's
- D. his or her

27. Each member of the expedition was required to carry _____ own provisions for a week.

- A. their
- B. his or her
- C. its
- D. themselves

28. Both the plaintiff and the defendant in the landmark case presented _____ arguments with compelling conviction.

- A. his or her
- B. its
- C. their
- D. his

29. Physics is one of the sciences that has seen _____ fundamental principles challenged in the last century.

- A. its
- B. their
- C. his
- D. her

30. The number of applicants has exceeded all expectations, but the quality of _____ submissions varies greatly.

- A. its
- B. their
- C. his or her
- D. their's

31. My mentor and trusted advisor, who has guided me for years, is finally retiring and selling _____ consultancy firm.

- A. their
- B. his
- C. its
- D. our

32. The media, in their relentless pursuit of a story, often disregard the privacy of the individuals involved.

- A. their
- B. its
- C. his or her
- D. it's

33. Every one of the shareholders has cast _____ vote.

- A. their
- B. his or her
- C. their's
- D. its

34. What the team needs now is not more resources, but a leader who can unite _____ disparate talents.

- A. their
- B. its
- C. his
- D. it's

35. Either the schematics are incorrect, or the lead engineer has made a mistake in _____ calculations.

- A. their
- B. his or her
- C. its
- D. theirs

36. The archipelago, a chain of volcanic islands, has _____ unique ecosystem threatened by climate change.

- A. their
- B. they're
- C. its
- D. it's

37. No one in the senior management team was willing to put _____ name to the controversial proposal.

- A. their
- B. his or her
- C. there
- D. its

38. The public is growing increasingly skeptical of political promises and the politicians who make _____.

- A. it
- B. them
- C. their
- D. its

39. Mumps is one of those diseases that, despite being preventable, still has _____ occasional outbreaks.

- A. its
- B. their
- C. his
- D. her

40. The crux of the matter, encompassing all the peripheral issues, is that the organization has lost _____ moral compass.

- A. their
- B. his or her
- C. its
- D. it's

41. Each of the defendants maintained _____ innocence throughout the prolonged trial.

- A. their
- B. his
- C. her
- D. his or her

42. The company, as well as its main competitors, has announced _____ third-quarter earnings.

- A. its
- B. their
- C. their's
- D. it's

43. Anybody wishing to participate in the symposium must register _____ interest by Friday.

- A. their
- B. his or her
- C. its
- D. themselves

44. The government is considering new legislation, but _____ efficacy is a subject of intense debate.

- A. it's
- B. their
- C. his or her
- D. its

45. It is I who _____ responsible for ensuring the team submits its report on time.

- A. is
- B. are
- C. am
- D. be

46. The pair of peregrine falcons has built _____ nest atop the skyscraper.

- A. their
- B. its
- C. they're
- D. his and her

47. Not only the employees but also the CEO had to admit _____ culpability in the financial scandal.

- A. their
- B. his or her
- C. its
- D. theirs

48. The audience showed _____ appreciation with a standing ovation.

- A. their
- B. its
- C. it's
- D. his or her

49. Several of the ancient manuscripts had _____ pages damaged by moisture.

- A. its
- B. their
- C. his or her
- D. theirs

50. This is the very species of orchid that has _____ habitat threatened by deforestation.

- A. their
- B. whose
- C. its
- D. which

✓ Answer Key & Explanations

1. The board of directors, after a contentious six-hour meeting, finally reached a consensus on _____ new strategic direction.

✓ Answer: B

💡 **Explanation:** The antecedent is 'The board of directors'. Although it consists of multiple people, the sentence emphasizes that they acted as a single unit ('reached a consensus'). Therefore, a singular pronoun 'its' is required. 'Their' would be used if the members were acting individually. 'It's' is a contraction for 'it is'. 'Theirs' is a possessive pronoun used to replace 'its direction'.

2. Each of the researchers, despite facing innumerable setbacks, was resolute in _____ pursuit of a breakthrough.

✓ Answer: B

💡 **Explanation:** The antecedent is 'Each', which is a singular indefinite pronoun. Therefore, a singular possessive pronoun is needed. 'His or her' is the grammatically correct and gender-inclusive singular form. While singular 'their' is gaining acceptance, 'his or her' is often preferred in formal C1-C2 level writing. 'Its' is for non-persons. 'Theirs' is the wrong form.

3. Dr. Alistair is one of those formidable academics who never shy away from challenging _____ own established theories.

✓ Answer: B

💡 **Explanation:** This is a classic 'one of those who...' structure. The antecedent of 'who' is not 'Dr. Alistair' (one), but 'those formidable academics' (plural). Therefore, the pronoun must be plural: 'their'.

4. Neither the sprawling metropolis nor the quaint surrounding villages could retain _____ historical character in the face of rapid modernization.

✓ Answer: B

💡 **Explanation:** This sentence uses the 'neither...nor' construction. According to the proximity rule, the pronoun must agree with the antecedent closer to it, which is 'the quaint surrounding villages' (plural). Therefore, the plural pronoun 'their' is correct.

5. A number of esoteric documents, long thought to be lost, have had _____ authenticity verified by a team of leading historians.

✓ Answer: D

💡 **Explanation:** The phrase 'A number of' is treated as plural, referring to multiple items. The antecedent is 'documents' (plural). Thus, the plural possessive pronoun 'their' is required. In contrast, 'The number of' would be treated as singular.

6. The jury delivered _____ verdict unanimously, finding the defendant not guilty on all counts.

✓ Answer: B

💡 **Explanation:** 'The jury' is a collective noun. In this context, the jury is acting as a single, unified body ('unanimously'), so the singular pronoun 'its' is the most appropriate choice.

7. Everybody who has ever grappled with existential philosophy must, at some point, confront _____ own mortality.

✓ Answer: C

💡 **Explanation:** 'Everybody' is a singular indefinite pronoun. In formal writing, the corresponding singular possessive pronoun 'his or her' is the most precise choice. Singular 'their' is also widely used but 'his or her' is often considered more formal and is a better fit for this sentence's tone.

8. The phenomenon of quantum entanglement, as well as its perplexing implications, has _____ roots in the early 20th century.

✓ **Answer:** A

💡 **Explanation:** The subject of the sentence is 'The phenomenon of quantum entanglement' (singular). The phrase 'as well as its perplexing implications' is an intervening phrase that does not change the number of the subject. Therefore, the singular pronoun 'its' is correct.

9. Some of the antiquated software is so unreliable that _____ continued use poses a significant security risk.

✓ **Answer:** A

💡 **Explanation:** The pronoun 'some' takes its number from the object of the preposition that follows. Here, 'software' is an uncountable noun, so it is treated as singular. Thus, the singular possessive pronoun 'its' is correct.

10. It is not the politicians but the electorate that must ultimately bear the responsibility for _____ choices.

✓ **Answer:** C

💡 **Explanation:** In the 'not...but...' construction, the verb and subsequent pronouns agree with the subject that is not negated. Here, the antecedent is 'the electorate'. 'Electorate' is a collective noun that, in this context, refers to the individual voters making choices, so the plural pronoun 'their' is appropriate.

11. Neither of the proposed solutions seems to offer _____ proponents a clear path to success.

✓ Answer: A

💡 **Explanation:** The word 'Neither' as the subject is always singular. Therefore, it requires a singular possessive pronoun. 'Its' is the correct choice, referring to 'Neither of the proposed solutions'.

12. The alumni of the university, who now hold influential positions globally, often credit _____ alma mater for their success.

✓ Answer: C

💡 **Explanation:** The antecedent is 'The alumni', which is the plural form of alumnus. Therefore, a plural pronoun, 'their', is required to refer to the group of graduates.

13. Every cog and wheel in the intricate mechanism has _____ own specific function.

✓ Answer: A

💡 **Explanation:** When a compound subject is preceded by 'every' (or 'each'), it is treated as singular. 'Every cog and wheel' refers to each individual part, making the subject singular. Thus, 'its' is the correct pronoun.

14. All of the information disseminated by the agency had _____ sources carefully redacted.

✓ Answer: B

💡 **Explanation:** The pronoun 'All' depends on the noun that follows. 'Information' is an uncountable noun and therefore singular. The correct possessive pronoun is the singular 'its'.

15. The committee members are currently embroiled in a debate among _____ about the allocation of funds.

✓ Answer: C

💡 **Explanation:** The antecedent is 'The committee members' (plural). The context of a debate among them indicates they are acting as individuals, not a single unit. Therefore, the plural reflexive pronoun 'themselves' is correct. 'Theirselves' is non-standard English.

16. He is the only one of the programmers who understands how to debug the legacy system on _____ own.

✓ Answer: A

💡 **Explanation:** This is a tricky exception to the 'one of those who' rule. The phrase 'the only one' singles out one specific person from the group. Therefore, the antecedent of 'who' becomes the singular 'one', and the pronoun must be singular: 'his'.

17. Mathematics, along with theoretical physics, has _____ own set of immutable laws.

✓ Answer: C

💡 **Explanation:** The subject of the sentence is 'Mathematics' (singular, as a field of study). The phrase 'along with theoretical physics' is an intervening phrase and does not affect the subject's number. Thus, the singular possessive 'its' is correct.

18. Many a political pundit has had to retract _____ predictions after an unexpected election result.

✓ Answer: B

💡 **Explanation:** The expression 'many a' is a formal and somewhat archaic structure that is always followed by a singular noun ('pundit') and is treated as singular. Therefore, the singular pronoun 'his or her' is the correct choice.

19. Either the regional managers or the vice president will have to present _____ revised proposal at the summit.

✓ Answer: D

💡 **Explanation:** Following the proximity rule for 'either...or', the pronoun agrees with the closer antecedent, which is 'the vice president' (singular). To be gender-inclusive and formal, 'his or her' is the best answer.

20. The United States, despite its diverse population, holds _____ elections every four years.

✓ Answer: C

💡 **Explanation:** Countries, even those with plural-sounding names like 'The United States' or 'The Philippines', are generally treated as singular entities. Therefore, the singular possessive pronoun 'its' is correct.

21. The flock of migratory birds makes _____ arduous journey south every autumn.

✓ Answer: A

💡 **Explanation:** 'The flock' is a collective noun. Here, the flock is acting as a single unit, making one journey together. Therefore, the singular pronoun 'its' is the correct choice.

22. None of the delegates were willing to compromise on _____ core principles.

✓ Answer: D

💡 **Explanation:** The pronoun 'None' takes its number from the object of the preposition. Here, 'delegates' is plural. Therefore, the plural possessive pronoun 'their' is correct. Note that while 'none' can sometimes be singular, with a plural noun like 'delegates' and a context of individual principles, plural is strongly preferred.

23. The plethora of data available has overwhelmed the analysts, making _____ task of finding a clear trend nearly impossible.

✓ Answer: A

💡 **Explanation:** The antecedent for the pronoun is 'the analysts' (plural), not 'plethora' or 'data'. The pronoun must refer to the people whose task it is. Therefore, the plural pronoun 'their' is correct.

24. A person who is perpetually indecisive often finds _____ caught between equally unappealing options.

✓ Answer: C

💡 **Explanation:** The antecedent is 'A person' (singular, non-gender-specific). The correct singular reflexive pronoun is 'himself or herself'. 'Themselves' is plural. 'Themselves' is a non-standard but increasingly common singular reflexive form, but 'himself or herself' is the standard for formal writing.

25. It was the CEO, not her subordinates, who had to stake _____ entire reputation on the risky venture.

✓ Answer: B

💡 **Explanation:** The antecedent is clearly 'the CEO', who is identified as female by the pronoun 'her' earlier in the sentence ('her subordinates'). Therefore, the correct possessive pronoun must be 'her'.

26. The company's new AI, an amalgam of various complex algorithms, constantly updates _____ own programming.

✓ Answer: B

💡 **Explanation:** The antecedent is 'The company's new AI' (singular, neuter). Therefore, the singular possessive pronoun 'its' is the correct choice.

27. Each member of the expedition was required to carry _____ own provisions for a week.

✓ Answer: B

💡 **Explanation:** 'Each member' is singular. The most formally correct pronoun is the singular 'his or her'. While singular 'their' is common, 'his or her' fits the formal tone of the sentence better.

28. Both the plaintiff and the defendant in the landmark case presented _____ arguments with compelling conviction.

✓ Answer: C

💡 **Explanation:** A compound antecedent joined by 'and' ('the plaintiff and the defendant') is plural. Therefore, the plural possessive pronoun 'their' is required.

29. Physics is one of the sciences that has seen _____ fundamental principles challenged in the last century.

✓ Answer: A

💡 **Explanation:** This question tests whether you misapply the 'one of those who' rule. The antecedent of 'that' is 'sciences' (plural), so the verb is 'have' (which is missing, but implied). However, the second part of the sentence refers back to the main subject, 'Physics' (singular). 'Physics...has seen its principles challenged.' Therefore, 'its' is correct.

30. The number of applicants has exceeded all expectations, but the quality of _____ submissions varies greatly.

✓ Answer: B

💡 **Explanation:** The pronoun refers to the 'applicants' (plural), not 'the number' (singular). It is the applicants' submissions that vary. Therefore, the plural pronoun 'their' is correct.

31. My mentor and trusted advisor, who has guided me for years, is finally retiring and selling _____ consultancy firm.

✓ Answer: B

💡 **Explanation:** The compound subject 'My mentor and trusted advisor' refers to a single person. This is a compound predicate describing one individual. Therefore, a singular pronoun ('his' or 'her' - 'his' is provided) is correct.

32. The media, in their relentless pursuit of a story, often disregard the privacy of the individuals involved.

✓ Answer: A

💡 **Explanation:** 'The media' is a collective noun. In this context, it refers to the various journalists, reporters, and news organizations acting as separate entities in pursuit of a story. This individual action makes the plural 'their' appropriate.

33. Every one of the shareholders has cast _____ vote.

✓ Answer: B

💡 **Explanation:** The phrase 'Every one' is definitively singular. It singles out each individual. Therefore, the formally correct singular possessive pronoun is 'his or her'.

34. What the team needs now is not more resources, but a leader who can unite _____ disparate talents.

✓ Answer: B

💡 **Explanation:** The pronoun refers to 'the team'. The goal is to 'unite' the talents, suggesting a focus on the team as a single entity. The talents belong to the team (singular unit). Therefore, 'its' is the best choice.

35. Either the schematics are incorrect, or the lead engineer has made a mistake in _____ calculations.

✓ Answer: B

💡 **Explanation:** Using the proximity rule for 'either...or', the pronoun must agree with the closer antecedent, 'the lead engineer' (singular). 'His or her' is the correct singular, gender-neutral pronoun.

36. The archipelago, a chain of volcanic islands, has _____ unique ecosystem threatened by climate change.

✓ Answer: C

💡 **Explanation:** The subject is 'The archipelago' (singular), which refers to a single chain of islands. The appositive 'a chain of volcanic islands' confirms its singular nature. Therefore, the singular possessive 'its' is correct.

37. No one in the senior management team was willing to put _____ name to the controversial proposal.

✓ Answer: B

💡 **Explanation:** 'No one' is a singular indefinite pronoun. In formal English, it requires a singular possessive pronoun, 'his or her'.

38. The public is growing increasingly skeptical of political promises and the politicians who make _____.

✓ Answer: B

💡 **Explanation:** The pronoun here refers to the antecedent 'political promises' (plural). Therefore, the plural object pronoun 'them' is correct.

39. Mumps is one of those diseases that, despite being preventable, still has _____ occasional outbreaks.

✓ Answer: A

💡 **Explanation:** This is a complex case. The relative clause 'that... has its occasional outbreaks' refers back to 'Mumps', not 'diseases'. 'Mumps' is the specific disease being discussed that has outbreaks. Since 'Mumps' (the disease) is singular, the pronoun 'its' is correct.

40. The crux of the matter, encompassing all the peripheral issues, is that the organization has lost _____ moral compass.

✓ Answer: C

💡 **Explanation:** The subject of the sentence is 'The crux' (singular). However, the pronoun refers to 'the organization' (a singular collective noun). Therefore, the singular possessive pronoun 'its' is the correct choice.

41. Each of the defendants maintained _____ innocence throughout the prolonged trial.

✓ Answer: D

💡 **Explanation:** The subject is 'Each', which is always singular. It refers to 'defendants' of unknown gender. The most grammatically precise option in formal writing is 'his or her'.

42. The company, as well as its main competitors, has announced _____ third-quarter earnings.

✓ Answer: A

💡 **Explanation:** The subject of the sentence is 'The company' (singular). The phrase 'as well as its main competitors' is an intervening phrase that does not alter the number of the subject. The pronoun must agree with 'The company', so 'its' is correct.

43. Anybody wishing to participate in the symposium must register _____ interest by Friday.

✓ Answer: B

💡 **Explanation:** 'Anybody' is a singular indefinite pronoun. The correct formal pronoun is the singular 'his or her'. While singular 'their' is widely accepted, 'his or her' is often considered the standard for formal instructions like this.

44. The government is considering new legislation, but _____ efficacy is a subject of intense debate.

✓ Answer: D

💡 **Explanation:** The pronoun refers to 'new legislation' (singular, uncountable). 'Government' can be singular or plural, but the thing whose efficacy is being debated is the legislation. Therefore, the singular pronoun 'its' is correct.

45. It is I who _____ responsible for ensuring the team submits its report on time.

✓ Answer: C

💡 **Explanation:** While this is a verb agreement question, it follows the same principle. The relative pronoun 'who' refers to the antecedent 'I'. Therefore, the verb must agree with 'I', which is 'am'. This illustrates how relative pronoun agreement works.

46. The pair of peregrine falcons has built _____ nest atop the skyscraper.

✓ Answer: B

💡 **Explanation:** The subject is 'The pair' (singular), not 'falcons'. 'Pair' is a singular noun referring to a single unit. Therefore, the singular pronoun 'its' is correct. If the sentence was 'The two falcons have built...', 'their' would be correct.

47. Not only the employees but also the CEO had to admit _____ culpability in the financial scandal.

✓ Answer: B

💡 **Explanation:** In a 'not only...but also' construction, the pronoun agrees with the antecedent closer to it. Here, that is 'the CEO' (singular). Therefore, 'his or her' is the correct choice.

48. The audience showed _____ appreciation with a standing ovation.

✓ Answer: B

💡 **Explanation:** 'The audience' is a collective noun. Here, the audience is acting in unison as a single entity ('a standing ovation'). Therefore, the singular possessive pronoun 'its' is appropriate.

49. Several of the ancient manuscripts had _____ pages damaged by moisture.

✓ Answer: B

💡 **Explanation:** The antecedent is 'Several', which is a plural indefinite pronoun. It refers to the 'manuscripts' (plural). Therefore, the plural pronoun 'their' is the correct choice.

50. This is the very species of orchid that has _____ habitat threatened by deforestation.

✓ Answer: C

💡 **Explanation:** The antecedent is 'species' (singular in this context, referring to one type). Therefore, the singular possessive pronoun 'its' is required. 'Whose' could also fit grammatically, but 'its' is a more direct possessive pronoun in this structure.